

Glossary

Aerial root

A root that grows from the stem of a plant above the surface of the ground.

Algae

Plantlike, mostly water-dwelling, organisms such as seaweed, which contain the green pigment chlorophyll.

Anther

The part of the flower's stamen that produces pollen.

Bark

The tough outer layer of the roots, trunk, and branches of woody plants such as trees and shrubs.

Biofuel

A renewable fuel produced from plant matter, algae, or animal waste.

Bonsai

A tree or shrub grown in a pot and kept in miniature form by special pruning. Bonsai is also the name given to this type of pruning.

Bract

A specialized type of leaf. Bracts, sometimes brightly colored, help protect buds and flowers on some plants and can also serve to attract pollinators.

Bulb

Underground fleshy leaves that store food for a plant.

Buttress root

A root that grows out from the trunk of a tree, giving it extra support.

Canopy

An almost continuous layer of branches and leaves formed high above the ground by treetops.

Chlorophyll

A green pigment. Plants use the chlorophyll in their cells to harvest the energy in sunlight.

Compound leaf

A leaf that is divided into two or more leaflets.

Conifer

An evergreen tree or shrub that has needlelike leaves. All conifers bear cones.

Corm

A swollen, bulblike underground stem.

Cotyledon

The first food-storing leaf, or pair of leaves, formed inside a seed.

Deciduous

Describes a plant that sheds its leaves each year at the end of a growing season.

Dicot

A flowering plant that produces two seed leaves (cotyledons) when it first starts to grow.

Dormant

In an inactive state. Many plants become dormant in the winter or in times of drought, remaining alive but shutting down to save energy.

Drupe

A fleshy fruit, such as a plum or cherry, containing a single hard seed or stone.

Epiphyte

A plant that grows on another plant for support without taking nutrients from it.



Evergreen

A plant that keeps its leaves throughout the year.

Fertilization

The combination of a male cell from pollen and a female egg, which goes on to produce a young plant known as an embryo.

Floret

A small flower, usually one of many making up the head of a flower such as a daisy.

Fron

A long leaf that usually consists of smaller leaflets. They are seen in plants such as ferns and palms.

Fungus

Microorganisms including mushrooms and toadstools. Fungi are more closely related to animals than to plants.

Germination

The process in which a seed starts to sprout and grow into a plant.

Harvest

The process of cutting and gathering crops from the field when ripe.

Host plant

A plant that is used by another for support and/or nutrients.

